

The Riddle Railway

Allen Girls Adventures

Allen Girls Adventures · Library Labyrinth Edition

Chapter 1 — The Track Between Shelves

The Labyrinth Library had corridors that curved like questions, but none of them moved on wheels until Tuesday.

Maya found the brass rail first. It ran along the baseboard of Aisle Fourteen, so thin she almost mistook it for decorative trim. Then she heard it: a cheerful chug-chug-chug, like a kettle learning to travel.

A miniature train rounded the corner. It was no longer than Maya's arm, painted deep purple with gold trim, pulling three open cars lined in velvet. The engine wore a tiny lantern and a nameplate that read: RIDDLE EXPRESS.

"Please present ticket or curiosity," said a voice from the smokestack. Not smoke came out, but silver letters that dissolved before they hit the floor.

SPARK rolled forward, antenna bright. "Automated transit system detected. Destination unknown. Safety rating: whimsical."

Alana knelt to inspect the wheels. They did not touch the floor quite normally; they hovered a hair above the rail, humming with library magic. Natalia read the schedule posted on a shelf peg:

STATIONS OF THE RIDDLE RAILWAY 1. Platform of Beginnings 2. Junction of Almost 3. The Turnaround of Too Loud 4. The Quiet Cut 5. The Last Stop (team ticket required)

"Team ticket," Maya repeated. "We are literally a team."

Natalia smiled. "Then we should board before it leaves without us."

They climbed into the second car. The train chimed once, friendly and firm, and glided along the rail between biography stacks and adventure stacks, between maps that curled at the edges and poetry that rustled like birds.

On the wall, a painted sign flashed:

FIRST RIDDLE: What travels the library without ever checking out a book?

Maya shouted, "Us!"

The train bell rang approval and accelerated.

Alana wrote in her notebook: Hypothesis — railway tests cooperation, not IQ.

SPARK added: Also tests willingness to look ridiculous in public.

Maya saluted. "Already qualified."

The train passed under a arch of hanging bookmarks, each one stamped with a question someone had once been

afraid to ask. Natalia reached up and touched one: How do I know if I belong here?

The bookmark warmed and changed to: You are here. That is today's answer.

SPARK recorded the exchange. Alana labeled it Platform Zero in her notebook — the moment before the first official stop.

Maya leaned from the car, wind in her braids, grinning at shelves that blurred past like pages in a hurry. "Faster!" she called.

The engine did not speed up. It chimed once, gentle and firm, as if saying: This railway rewards arrival, not racing.

Natalia appreciated that. She sat back and watched the rail glow faint gold beneath them, a path made visible only because a team was riding it.

Readers on ladders pointed as the train passed. A cart of overdue books paused to let them through. A cat-shaped bookmark darted across the rail and vanished into Mythology.

"This is the best aisle," Maya declared.

"It is not on the floor plan," Alana said, delighted.

SPARK overlaid a temporary map. "Riddle Railway exists only during cooperative transit. Note for field guide."

They rounded a corner and found a pop-up station no schedule had listed: Platform of Encouragement. No riddle. Just a board where teams pinned notes for the next riders.

Maya pinned: YOU DO NOT NEED TO BE FAST.

Alana pinned: YOU NEED TO BE TOGETHER.

Natalia pinned: YOU ARE ALREADY ENOUGH TO START.

The train chimed and rolled on, leaving the platform glowing behind them like a nightlight.

Chapter 2 — Platform of Beginnings

The first station was a pocket platform carved into a hollow shelf, complete with a bench, a clock that ran backward, and a ticket punch shaped like a moon.

They stepped down. The train waited, patient as a polite dog.

A chalkboard stood beside the bench:

I have keys but open no locks. I have space but hold no boxes. I have roads but carry no cars. What am I?

Maya snapped her fingers. "A keyboard!"

The chalkboard erased itself and wrote: Close. Try again with library love.

Natalia looked around the platform. Keys on key-hooks by the catalog. Space between shelves. Roads in floor inlay.

"A map," she said softly.

The bench warmed. The clock ticked forward one minute.

"Maps have keys — legends," Alana said. "Space — margins. Roads — routes."

The chalkboard flashed green: Correct. Board when ready.

They reboarded. The train climbed a spiral ramp between shelves, passing windows that showed not outside but other aisles, as if the library were folding itself into a smaller shape to let them through.

Maya leaned out carefully. "This is the best thing ever."

"Statistically improbable," SPARK said, "but emotionally accurate."

At the top of the spiral, a second sign appeared:

SECOND RIDDLE: Name the thing readers leave behind when they finish a good story.

Natalia answered without hesitation: "A part of themselves."

The lantern on the engine brightened.

Alana added, "And sometimes a bookmark."

SPARK said, "And thermal gratitude. I experience it as a 0.4 degree warmth event."

The train chimed and carried them onward.

Chapter 3 — Junction of Almost

Station two was wider, with three tracks and a ceiling painted like night sky. Wooden signs pointed in directions that did not exist on any floor plan Alana had seen.

The riddle here was spoken, not written. A gentle voice from the ticket booth asked:

"I am what you almost say when you are afraid of being wrong. What am I?"

Maya opened her mouth, then closed it. She hated almost-answers.

Natalia touched her sleeve. "Take a real try."

Maya exhaled. "Silence?"

"Almost," the booth said.

Alana frowned. "Hesitation."

"Almost."

SPARK projected a list: pause, doubt, maybe, retreat.

Natalia closed her eyes. She thought of all the times she had almost raised her hand, almost spoken first, almost believed she belonged in the deep stacks.

"Almost itself," she said. "The word almost."

The booth laughed like wind through pages. "Correct. You cannot ride past Almost until you name it."

The middle track lit up. The train switched rails with a smooth click.

In the car, Maya bumped Natalia's shoulder. "Good catch."

"It felt familiar," Natalia admitted.

Alana made a note: Railway mirrors internal obstacles, not trivia.

They passed shelves of books bound in question-mark cloth. SPARK scanned one title: How to Ask Better Questions by Not Rushing the Answer.

"Recommended reading," he said.

Maya groaned. "The train is judging us."

"Encouraging you," Natalia corrected.

The third riddle appeared on the seatbacks:

What gets stronger when shared and weaker when hoarded?

Maya and Alana spoke together: "Knowledge."

Natalia added, "And courage."

The train bell rang twice.

They shared the third riddle with a lost delivery cart that had rolled onto the wrong aisle. Maya waved it clear. Alana helped reroute. Natalia reassured the nervous page-bearer that wrong turns in libraries were usually recoverable.

"Team ticket includes roadside assistance," SPARK noted.

At Junction of Almost, they met another team — two brothers and a cousin — stuck on the same riddle. Instead of competing, the girls offered hints without answers.

"Name the almost," Natalia told them.

The cousin tried three times, then whispered, "Almost asked for help."

The junction lights flared. Both trains proceeded.

Maya cheered. "Double railway win."

"Shared win," Alana corrected, writing it down.

Chapter 4 — The Turnaround of Too Loud

Station three shook with noise.

Not dangerous noise — parade noise. Brass band noise. Story noise. Shelves vibrated with enthusiastic echoes.

A sign demanded:

To pass, answer without shouting: What is louder than a shout but softer than a whisper?

Maya immediately yelled, "EVERYTHING!"

The noise doubled. The train windows rattled.

Alana pressed her palms to her ears. "Maya."

"Sorry," Maya said, quieter. "I got excited."

Natalia stepped onto the platform and faced the sign. She waited until the echoes settled.

"A feeling," she said. "When you are proud of someone and you do not know how to say it right."

The noise thinned to a hum.

SPARK tilted his head. "Secondary acceptable answer: shared laughter."

The turnaround wheel spun. The train reversed direction on a loop shaped like a question mark, then continued forward on a new rail.

Maya sat on her hands. "I will practice indoor voice science."

Alana handed her a sticky note: Volume is not enthusiasm's only outfit.

They rode through a tunnel lined with mirrors. Each reflection showed a different moment from their library adventures: finding the golden key, mending lanterns, singing with sealed books, harvesting glass fruit.

Maya went quiet.

"Those were loud days too," she said. "But good loud."

Natalia nodded. "Good loud counts."

At tunnel's end, the fourth riddle glowed on the ceiling:

What turns a mistake into a lesson?

Alana answered: "Honesty afterward."

Maya answered: "Trying again."

Natalia answered: "Someone staying with you while you fix it."

The tunnel brightened white-gold and opened into cold air.

In the mirror tunnel they saw not only past adventures but possible futures: Maya shelving without rushing, Alana presenting a discovery without apologizing first, Natalia reading aloud to a full room.

"Scary futures," Maya said, only half joking.

"Good scary," Natalia said. "Like roller coasters."

SPARK displayed a tip: Loud stations test volume control. Quiet stations test presence. Both are skills.

They practiced — Maya counted to ten before answering the ceiling riddle. Her second answer came softer and stronger.

Alana noticed the train slowed when they listened to one another. "Cooperation is fuel," she said.

The engine chimed agreement.

Chapter 5 — The Quiet Cut

Station four was so quiet they heard their own blinking.

Snow seemed to fall indoors, though flakes dissolved before touching the floor. A bench held three warm scarves that were not there a second before.

The riddle was written in frost on the window:

What must you carry into silence so silence does not become loneliness?

No one spoke for a long moment.

Maya hated long silence. She tapped her knee, then stopped.

Alana whispered, "Attention."

SPARK whispered back, "Presence."

Natalia looked at her sisters and the small robot who had become family in every practical sense.

"Company," she said. "Chosen company."

The frost melted into a smile shape.

They wrapped the scarves around their shoulders and reboarded. The train moved slower here, respectful of the quiet cut between wings of the library where repair crews worked on cracked spines and loose pages.

Workers waved from ladders. One called, "Riddle train still running?"

"Still learning," Maya called back, softly.

At the end of the quiet cut, a child reader sat on a stool, stuck on a hard word. Natalia jumped down before the train fully stopped.

"Want help?" she asked.

The child nodded.

They sounded the word together. The train waited without complaint.

When Natalia climbed back in, the engine chimed like approval.

SPARK displayed: Unscheduled kindness stops add no delay in moral time.

Maya smiled. "Put that on a poster."

The fifth riddle arrived as a paper strip on the seat:

What is the ticket for the last stop?

Maya frowned. "We already answered team ticket."

"Maybe that was the advertisement," Alana said. "Not the ticket itself."

They discussed possibilities as the train crept through the quiet cut. Trust. Patience. Shared credit. The willingness to look foolish together.

Maya suggested "friendship" as the ticket. SPARK suggested "reciprocal effort." Natalia suggested "showing up when it is not your turn yet."

Each answer made the paper strip glow partial gold.

"Combination ticket," Alana said. "We have to answer together again."

They did — three voices, one sentence: We ride for each other.

The strip dissolved into starlight and reappeared as a stamp on their sleeves: QUIET CUT PASSED.

Chapter 6 — The Wrong Platform

The train slowed at a false station labeled VICTORY WITHOUT EFFORT.

Candy-colored benches. Applause speakers. A banner that declared YOU ARE ALREADY DONE.

Maya's eyes lit. "I love this station."

Natalia did not. "It feels like skipping chapters."

Alana read the fine print on the banner: Exit here if you prefer answers without questions.

SPARK's glow turned amber. "Warning: shortcut may remove meaningful context."

A vendor cart offered medals for riddles never attempted.

Maya reached for one. Natalia gently caught her wrist.

"Remember Almost Station," she said.

Maya swallowed. "Yeah. Okay."

They stayed on the train. The false station faded behind them like a dream forgetting itself.

The rail climbed steeply now, between shelves so high the top rows vanished in purple mist. Wind carried paper scent and distant bells.

A new riddle formed in condensation on the window:

What is heavier: being right alone or being wrong together?

Alana answered first. "Being right alone."

Maya answered second. "Being wrong together — but only if you stop fixing it."

Natalia answered last. "Being right alone, if it makes you leave people behind."

The window cleared.

SPARK said quietly, "Correct composite answer registered."

They held hands without planning to. The train entered a corkscrew curve where gravity felt optional.

At the curve's peak, they saw the whole labyrinth spread below like a map drawn by someone who loved readers.

"Wow," Maya breathed.

"We are still not at the last stop," Natalia said.

"Good," Alana replied. "I have one more notebook page."

They wrote observations as the train climbed: which riddles needed one voice, which needed three, which needed silence first. Maya drew the false station with a big X through it. Natalia drew the child from the quiet cut sounding out a victorious word.

SPARK added a safety note: Shortcut stations appear when teams are tired. Rest is permitted. Quitting on each other is not.

They rested anyway — cocoa appeared in the cup holders, steam smelling like cinnamon and pencil shavings. Maya leaned on Natalia's shoulder. Alana recalibrated her pen.

"Ready for the bridge?" Natalia asked.

Maya sat up. "Born ready."

"Statistically unlikely," SPARK said.

"Emotionally true," Maya replied.

Chapter 7 — The Broken Bridge of Maybe

Before the final approach, the rail crossed a tiny bridge over a gap between shelves. Half the bridge was missing.

A sign read:

RIDDLE BRIDGE ACTIVATION REQUIRED What do you build when you do not have enough planks?

Maya looked at the gap. "A jump?"

"Unsafe," SPARK said.

Alana examined the remaining planks. "A rope?"

"No rope," Natalia said. She pointed to the open train car. "A chain of us."

They unlinked the velvet seats, passed them hand to hand, and formed a living bridge rail: Maya anchoring at the engine, Alana in the middle, Natalia at the gap, SPARK stabilizing with magnetic grip.

The train rolled across their joined arms one careful wheel at a time.

It was ridiculous. It was terrifying. It was funny.

When the last wheel crossed, they collapsed laughing on the far side.

The bridge repaired itself behind them, planks growing back like teeth in a smile.

A chalk voice said: Correct. You built trust.

Maya wiped her eyes. "I thought riddles were word games."

"Best ones are life games," Natalia said.

They reassembled the seats. The train continued.

The sky-painted ceiling lowered into a dome. Stars were not stars but punctuation marks drifting softly: commas, question marks, ellipses waiting for sentences to continue.

The sixth riddle shimmered:

What punctuation fits the end of a day spent trying?

Maya: "Ellipsis..."

Alana: "Comma, because tomorrow continues."

Natalia: "Question mark, if you learned something new."

All three answers were accepted.

The train slowed toward a platform wrapped in gold ribbon.

Maya's arms ached from the bridge stunt. Alana massaged her shoulder without being asked. Natalia checked everyone's hands for splinters — none, only velvet fuzz and pride.

"Would you do it again?" SPARK asked.

"For the team?" Maya said. "Obviously."

"For a solo medal?" Alana asked.

Maya made a face. "Pass."

They passed a shelf where books about trains leaned toward the rail as if listening. One cover showed the Riddle Express in miniature. Natalia tucked a note inside: We crossed on trust.

The note glowed and became a bookmark for the next reader.

"Railway kindness deposits," SPARK said. "Interest rate: high."

Chapter 8 — The Last Stop Appears

The Last Stop had no riddles on its sign.

It said only:

THANK YOU FOR TRAVELING TOGETHER.

A small kiosk offered hot cocoa that tasted like cinnamon and homework finished early. They stepped onto the platform and looked back at the train.

The engine spoke:

"Final riddle approaching. Answer together."

The air itself seemed to listen.

The riddle appeared in three colors:

What did you learn on the Riddle Railway that you cannot learn alone?

Maya spoke first. "That almost is a real place and you can leave it."

Alana spoke second. "That being right is not the only useful thing."

Natalia spoke third. "That silence is not empty if someone you love is in it."

SPARK chimed. "That transit systems are excellent metaphors for friendship."

The platform rang like a bell made of pages.

Other teams arrived on parallel tracks — the brothers from Junction of Almost, a pair of librarians, a parent with two kids still in pajamas. Each group had different answers. The railway accepted them all.

Maya listened to a boy say, "I learned wrong answers can be funny if you are not mean."

Alana wrote that down on a spare ticket.

Natalia realized the Last Stop was not a finish line. It was a meeting room for lessons earned.

The kiosk offered toppings: marshmallows, star anise, tiny paper flags that said ASK AGAIN LATER.

They clinked cocoa cups. SPARK raised an antenna like a toast.

"To questions," Alana said.

"To teams," Natalia said.

"To trains that do not let you skip the hard stations," Maya said.

Chapter 9 — Tickets on Seed Paper

Inside the lead car sat three tickets printed on seed paper:

RETURN ANYTIME WITH NEW ANSWERS.

Maya hugged the engine — carefully, because it was warm and humming.

"Best railway ever."

"It is not on any map," Alana said.

"It will be now," Natalia replied, sketching the route on her cuff.

A conductor appeared — not a person, but a ribbon of light shaped like a bookmark. It stamped their tickets with tiny stars.

"Passengers who answer together may reboard when the library asks a hard question," it said.

SPARK stored the tickets in a dry envelope. "Valuable credentials."

They rode the return loop as evening settled over the stacks. Lanterns brightened one by one. Readers waved from windows cut into thick shelves.

A boy on a ladder called, "Did you win?"

Maya called back, "We arrived!"

The boy considered this, then nodded as if that were better.

On the return loop they helped a new team stuck at Turnaround of Too Loud — whispering strategies, demonstrating indoor voice, celebrating when the noise thinned.

Maya taught the victory chant: "We are loud about helping!"

Natalia taught the counter-chant: "We are soft about listening!"

Both worked.

SPARK stored route audio for training. Alana mapped station order for the field guide. The seed tickets in their pockets felt warm, as if already growing future answers.

Chapter 10 — The Rail Folds Away

At Aisle Fourteen, the brass line faded like a smile after a good joke.

Only a shallow groove remained in the wood, and the schedule peg now held a slim manual:

OPERATING THE RIDDLE RAILWAY (FOR TEAMS ONLY)

Alana read the first rule aloud: "No solo tickets."

"Good rule," Natalia said.

Second rule: "Return answers, not just arrivals."

Maya tapped the page. "Also good."

Third rule: "If you miss a stop, help someone else reach theirs."

They looked at one another and laughed because they had been doing that all along without calling it railway work.

A junior librarian asked if the rail could run on Wednesdays for reading clubs. The manual grew a new line: YES, IF A TEAM ASKS.

Maya volunteered immediately. Alana volunteered conditionally, if snacks were provided. Natalia volunteered if beginners were welcome.

SPARK volunteered to be conductor voice, which everyone accepted with delight.

They planted one seed ticket in a pot by Aisle Fourteen. By morning, a sprout with leaf-shaped questions had appeared.

"Library gardening," Maya said.

"Library logistics," Alana corrected.

Chapter 11 — Field Guide for Teams

On the shelf where the schedule had hung, a new book waited:

The Riddle Railway: A Field Guide for Teams.

Inside, their names were printed on the dedication page — not as authors, but as passengers who had paid with honesty.

The first chapter listed stations they recognized. The second chapter left blank pages for future teams.

Natalia wrote on the first blank page: Station of Asking for Help Without Shame.

Maya wrote: Station of Loud Joy That Does Not Hurt.

Alana wrote: Station of Measuring Less and Listening More.

SPARK added a footnote: Station of Carrying Friends Across Gaps.

The book accepted the entries and glowed once, like a lantern satisfied with its fuel.

Teams began visiting the field guide to add their own stations. Station of Asking for Directions Without Shame. Station of Laughing at the Wrong Answer and Trying Again. Station of Saving a Seat.

Each entry made the brass groove in Aisle Fourteen hum faintly on Tuesdays.

Alana indexed the stations by skill taught. Natalia indexed them by feeling healed. Maya indexed them by fun level — highly scientific, she insisted.

SPARK built a quiz for new riders: not trivia, self-knowledge. When do you shout? When do you pause? Who do you trust on the quiet cut?

Readers took the quiz before boarding. The railway grew kinder, not easier.

"That is the point," Natalia said.

Chapter 12 — Railway Day

Maya declared Tuesday official Railway Day.

They celebrated by helping a nervous reader choose a first chapter book, then by shelving returns together, then by sitting in the nook sharing cocoa while SPARK read platform rules in a dramatic voice.

Natalia said, "The last riddle was not a trick."

"No," Alana agreed. "It was a mirror."

"Mirrors again," Maya groaned. "This library loves mirrors."

"And trains," Natalia said. "And teams."

Somewhere distant, a tiny bell chimed chug-chug-chug, as if the Riddle Express were already waiting for the next curious passengers.

The labyrinth hummed agreement.

On the next Tuesday, Maya wore a conductor hat made of folded maps. Alana carried spare notebooks. Natalia greeted nervous teams at Platform of Beginnings.

The Riddle Express arrived on time, which in library time meant exactly when you were ready.

A first-time team failed the loud station twice. Maya did not tease. She demonstrated indoor voice science with dramatic flair until they laughed and succeeded.

The train bell rang approval. The new team stamped their sleeves: FIRST RIDE.

At day's end, the girls sat in their nook with cocoa and listened for the distant chug-chug-chug.

"It is still running," Natalia said.

"It will run whenever someone needs to learn together," Alana said.

Maya raised her cup. "To railways, mirrors, and teams who do not quit at Almost."

The labyrinth hummed again — softer this time, like a bedtime story satisfied with its ending.

THE END